But Thiruvalluvar deserves better, even if it means reading him in English – as in the first English translation of the *Thirukkural* by Francis Whyte Ellis, a Madras civil servant who has had the rare accolade of having recently had a district in Madurai named after him: Ellis Nagar. Here below are three of Ellis's couplets from Chapter VIII, on the subject of married love:

> *78. As in a barren soil a sapless tree,*
> *So flourish those in wedded bliss, whose souls*
> *Know not the sweets of love.*
>
> *79. What though the body each perfection own,*
> *If in the breast, the beauty of the mind,*
> *Exist not.*
>
> *80. That breast alone contains a living soul,*
> *Which love inspires; void of this genial warmth,*
> *'Tis bone o'erlaid with skin.*

This unfinished work was enough to inspire the French scholar Edouard-Simon Ariel to work on his own French translation, declaring in a letter to his eminent colleague Eugène Burnouf that what was so wonderful about these verses was that 'its author addresses himself, without regard to castes, peoples, or beliefs, to the whole community of mankind; the fact that he formulates sovereign morality and absolute reason; the fact that he proclaims in this very essence, in their eternal abstractness, virtue and truth … the tenderest emotions of the heart'.[1]

That sums it up very succinctly. No wonder, then, that for a great many South Indians the *Thirukkural* symbolises their *ulaga podhmarai* or 'common creed', as well as offering a guide to the good life lived in harmony with humanity and nature. At the very least, the *Thirukkural*'s 1330 melodious